

perfect score. The Altec Lansing GT-5051R also deserves a mention here. Coming to the mid and high frequencies, the verdict was once again in favour of Logitech—the Z-5500D demolished everything in its path. The Altec Lansing GT-5051R also performed well and came in a solid second. The Frontech JIL-1875 was once again trounced with below par scores.

We fired up the power handling tests next. We plugged in the Logitech Z-5500D first. After 10 minutes of listening to it, it was clear that this set was going to be hard to beat. The only speaker to come anywhere near the Logitech was the Altec Lansing GT-5051R.

The Zebronics ZEB-SW12000R and the Creative Inspire 5200 just could not keep up with the rest and posted the lowest scores. The Zebronics ZEB-SW10000R and the Intex IT-4900W did marginally better. A lot was expected from the Philips HTR5000, but it failed to deliver here.

Finally, some music! We did the audio CD tests first. No surprise, the Logitech Z-5500D once again went about its business ruthlessly, beating every speaker hollow in three out of the four audio CD tests—second place was a more closely contested affair. Most of the 5.1s did decently well in this test with average scores. The two Philips models (the HTR5000 and the MMS 5.500 i/C) did well here. Altec Lansing's GT-5051R and the 251i, the Artis S6600R and Creative's Inspire GD580 also deserve a mention.

The unpopular battle for last spot was also a closely contested affair—between the Intex IT-4900W and the Frontech JIL-1875.

The final test was the MP3 music: we played the evergreen *Hotel California* first. The Logitech Z-5500D made it sound like an Eagles concert. Even at high volumes there was barely any

distortion, and with this set, your ears start to protest before the speakers do. These speakers are very loud, and the 500-watt RMS label is very believable.

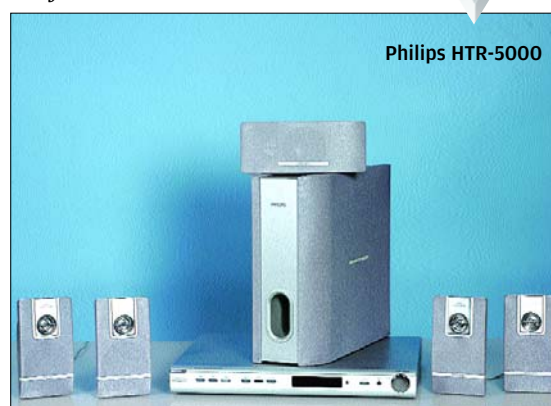
The Z-5500D took two out of the four tests outright, and tied for the third. The Philips MMS 5.500 i/C took second spot with the Artis S6600R. Another worthy mention here is the Philips HTR5000.

The Frontech JIL-1875 once again occupied bottom position proving that these aren't performance oriented at all.

Putting It All Together

We saw some strong performers emerge and other speakers get thrashed once subjected to our rigorous testing standards.

There is no clear choice for all users. The Altec Lansing MX-5021 performed superlatively in nearly all the tests it was subjected to, but it would be



hard to recommend to a casual music listener when cheaper 5.1 systems are available. For an audiophile who wants good music on his computer and wants sound as close to the original as possible, the MX-5021 is the speaker for you. Even after taking into account its considerably high price tag of Rs 7,900, the Altec Lansing came on tops in the 2.1 category leaving the

closest competition, its higher priced sibling Altec Lansing FX-6021, behind by miles. We did not need to have a second look before deciding that the Altec Lansing MX-5021 be awarded a well-deserved Digit Best Buy Gold. The Altec Lansing FX-6021, which did not perform too badly either, came in second and was awarded the Digit Best Buy Silver.

Coming to the 6 channels sets, for users with no budget constraints, we'd recommend the Logitech Z-5500D. This 500-watt monster rocked our labs with its front firing 10-inch woofer. It topped the performance charts in 70 per cent of the tests we put it through. Although the Z-5500D was by far the costliest speaker set of the lot, performance is guaranteed, and, oh, let's not forget the flaunt value!

We don't all have deep pockets, however, and for users looking to dabble in a bit of surround sound at an affordable price tag, the Artis S6600R and the Altec Lansing GT-5051R are good choices—they perform well and don't cost a bomb. Going even further down the price range, we recommend the Altec Lansing 251i—5.1 for under Rs 4K!

At the end of the day, a perfect combination of low price, good features and performance is what goes into deciding the winner. The Philips MMS 5.50 i/C did not fare poorly in any of the tests and was more or less an average performer. With an inbuilt FM radio and decent looks, it's sure to appeal to a wide audience. Add to all that a cost of just Rs 4,990, which is peanuts for a 5.1 speaker set, the Philips MMS 5.500 i/C was adjudged the winner of the Digit Best Buy Gold award.

Even though the Philips HTR5000 was priced much higher at Rs 12,990, it performed well in most of the tests thrown at it. It sports good looks, has an inbuilt FM radio and also has a decoder for DTS and Dolby Pro Logic II, because of which, watching (or rather listening to) compatible DVDs is a whole new experience! We found that the price of Rs 12,999 was not too much for a decently-performing 5.1 speaker set with so many features, and therefore, the Digit Best Buy Silver for this category goes to the Philips HTR5000! ☑

jayesh_limaye@thinkdigit.com
michael_browne@thinkdigit.com

Contact Sheet		Speakers		
Brand	Company	Phone	E-mail	Web Site
Altec Lansing	Rashi Peripherals	022-55090909	divya@rptechindia.com	www.alteclansing.com
Artis	Kunhar Peripherals Pvt Ltd	022-56345758	salesbom@kunhar.com	www.artis.co.in
Creative	Creative Asia Labs	9840160005	india_getcreative@ctl.creative.com	in.creative.com
Frontech	Jupiter International Ltd	022-3095682	frontech@bom5.vsnl.net.in	www.jil-jupiter.com
Genius	Transtek Infoways Pvt Ltd	95250-3250072	amit@ttek.in	www.geniusnet.com.tw
Gigabyte	Transtek Infoways Pvt Ltd	95250-3250072	amit@ttek.in	www.giga-byte.com
Intex	Intex Technologies	011-41610224	info@intextechnologies.com	www.intextechnologies.com
Logitech	Logitech Electronic India Pvt Ltd	022-26571160	response@logitech.com	www.logitech.com
Philips	Philips India Ltd	022-56912332	pcp.india.info@philips.com	india.philips.com
Tech-Com	Shree Sagarmatha Dist Pvt Ltd	011-26428541	contact@techcomindia.com	www.techcomindia.com
Umax	Neoteric	022-39828600	sales@neoteric.co.in	www.umax.com
Xfree	Transtek Infoways Pvt Ltd	95250-3250072	amit@ttek.in	NA
Zebronics	Topnotch Infotronics Pvt Ltd	044-26616202	zebronics@zebronics.com	www.zebronics.com